

Chapter 77-2

//

When Xu Qingzhu saw the message, she was sitting on the bed in a daze.

Sheng Linlang had gone back to her room to wash up. Xu Qingzhu sat there flipping through a photo album that Sheng Linlang had hidden away. Inside were many photos of Sheng Qinglin—a spirited young man.

He had the most fashionable hairstyle of that era, rode a cool motorcycle, and was dressed all in black.

There were also photos of him in his school uniform, standing out particularly brightly among the crowd.

Xu Qingzhu had inherited most of her appearance from him, so everyone often said she looked like her mother, when in reality she resembled Sheng Qinglin.

A young talent, who died in the prime of his youth.

One could only sigh regretfully and say that heaven was jealous of his brilliance.¹

Even unrelated strangers would wring their hands and sigh upon seeing this, let alone family members.

After Xu Qingzhu finished looking through those photos, combined with what Sheng Linlang had told her, she suddenly felt that this uncle she had never met in over twenty years had come alive.

No, perhaps she should call him father.

This person seemed to have once vividly existed in her life.

The photo album was still beside her when her phone vibrated slightly and the screen lit up.

Seeing it was a message from Liang Shi, she smiled and casually replied: [Very smoothly.]

Liang Shi: [That's good.]

Xu Qingzhu: [I won't be coming back tonight.]

Liang Shi: [Okay.]

Liang Shi responded very quickly. Xu Qingzhu stared at the screen, not knowing what else to say.

After a while, Liang Shi asked again: [Have you eaten dinner?]

Xu Qingzhu: [Already ate, how about you?]

Liang Shi: [Just ate.]

Xu Qingzhu finally thought of a topic to ask about: [Did you go to the nursing home and see Director Gu?]

Liang Shi: [Yes, but it didn't go very smoothly.]

Xu Qingzhu: [What happened?]

Liang Shi: [As soon as I mentioned Yang Jiani, he had an episode and kept saying "crazy person, crazy woman," so I couldn't find out anything.]

Xu Qingzhu could feel her helplessness even through the screen. Her finger paused on the screen for a moment, and after thinking for a few seconds, she replied: [Then that means Gu Xingyue is connected to Qi Jiao and Yang Jiani. Otherwise, why would Director Gu react like that? If we can't deduce it forward, we'll just deduce it backward. At least it wasn't a wasted trip.]

Liang Shi: [...Teacher Xu is clever.]

Xu Qingzhu: [It's Teacher Liang giving me the chance to show off.]

Liang Shi: [...]

"Who are you chatting with?" Sheng Linlang had changed into her pajamas, her hair still wet, and walked in to ask her, "Is it with Liang Shi? You look so happy chatting."

Xu Qingzhu raised her head, restraining her smile, and asked back, "Do I?"

She was just casually chatting with Liang Shi.

"Yes, you do." Sheng Linlang smiled and said, "Seeing that you two have a good relationship, I can rest easy."

Xu Qingzhu pouted, "Anyway, you all just want to marry me off and have me never come back."

"What kind of thing is that to say." Sheng Linlang gave her a light, sideways glance, "Who was the one who insisted on marrying Liang Shi back then? I tried to stop you."

"I know." Xu Qingzhu curved her lips into a light smile, "It was me."

Back then, Sheng Linlang had wanted her to date Liang Shi for a few years before getting married. After all, she had just graduated and was still young, and Liang Shi had that kind of reputation outside.

But she couldn't resist Liang Shi's relentless pursuit at the time, and with Minghui's decline, she wanted to help Minghui.

Moreover, she had genuinely wanted to marry Liang Shi back then. In her memories, she was still that warm older sister from childhood.

Various reasons stacked up, leading her to enter into marriage with Liang Shi without thinking it through clearly.

The result was disappointment that grew with each passing day.

But now...

Things seemed to have taken an unexpected turn.

Xu Qingzhu didn't tell Sheng Linlang about all the twists and turns. She just needed to let Sheng Linlang know that she had been doing quite well all along.

After their earlier conversation, Xu Qingzhu said she wanted to sleep with Sheng Linlang tonight—it had been too long since they had sat together and chatted.

Sheng Linlang went to bed early at night and was already sleepy by now.

Xu Qingzhu hurriedly washed up, turned off the lights, and lay on the bed snuggled up next to Sheng Linlang.

She didn't bother with her phone anymore.

Actually, it wasn't even close to Xu Qingzhu's usual bedtime, but she had been rushing around busy with work during the day, and after coming back in the evening, her nerves had been tense the whole time. Now, being with Sheng Linlang, she felt sleepy too.

Since they had opened up the topic of Sheng Qinglin, Sheng Linlang lay there telling her stories from their childhood.

Sheng Linlang said that one of Sheng Qinglin's good friends had pursued her back then. This made Sheng Qinglin so angry that he invited the guy to a boxing gym for a fight and told him: "You're not worthy of my sister."

The guy came to Sheng Linlang for comfort with his beaten-up face, and Sheng Linlang stomped on him several more times.

Because Sheng Qinglin's face had also been injured by the other guy.

There was another time when Sheng Qinglin went traveling out of town with a group of friends. Their major had a general education course with a particularly strict teacher who always took attendance. So he asked Sheng Linlang to help answer roll call for him.

It was Sheng Linlang's first time doing something like this, and it was Su Yao who helped her muddle through it.

She answered roll call for Su Yao, and Su Yao answered roll call for Sheng Linlang.²

After class, the two of them went to eat shaved ice³ at the school gate, and along the way, three people asked for their contact information.

Footnotes:

¹ "Heaven was jealous of his brilliance" (天妒英才, tiān dù yīng cái) - A Chinese idiom used to express sorrow when talented individuals die young. It implies that heaven itself was envious of their talent and took them away prematurely.

² This refers to a common practice in Chinese universities where attendance is taken by calling out names from a roster, and students must respond "到" (dào, meaning "here" or "present"). Friends sometimes help answer for absent classmates to avoid them being marked absent.

³ "Shaved ice" (吃冰) - A popular dessert in Chinese-speaking regions, consisting of finely shaved ice topped with various sweet toppings like fruit, condensed milk, red beans, or flavored syrups. It's especially popular in warm weather.